



BUILDER MAFIA

Property prices have tripled in two years as demand grows, but it has ruined the pristine skyline of Goa as builders, corrupt officials and politicians violate laws with impunity

fields are giving way to sprawling complexes and the shorelines are turning into concretised coasts with five-star hotels and shabby wall-to-wall shacks.

From a few seaside eateries in the early 1990s to nearly 400 legal and illegal shacks now, the beaches are teeming with drug peddlers and tourists alike—shopping for everything from beads to contraband. Being a popular tourist destination across the globe comes with its own share of problems. While tourism earns the state on an average Rs 4,000 crore annually with over 23 lakh tourists, and it contributes 15 per cent of India's foreign exchange earnings from tourism, Goa also attracts all kinds of people from celebrities to beachcombers and foreigners with dubious credentials, whom the locals call "white trash". Many of these lotus-eaters come on the pretext of a holiday and make Goa their home. Coming to India on long term visas, they stay with local village families, open bars and hawk drugs. What started off as eateries for people from different countries have now transformed into hubs for nefarious activities. These groups even control stretches of beaches in

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SHRIYA PATIL SHINDE



**FRANCISCO XAVIER
PACHECO, TOURISM MINISTER**

the state. Recently, a Russian shack owner at Morjim beach stopped an Indian tourist from taking pictures claiming it was his private beach. Says a senior police officer: "What type of tourists would want to live here illegally and try and earn a living? They live on welfare and come here since it's cheaper than most western countries."

The trouble-making foreigners are not restricted to the beaches alone. Certain five-star hotels along the coast are reserved by affluent Russians during the winter months. In fact, a few beaches and hotels have even put up signboards in Russian, a clear indication of their large numbers. Residents allege that the drug and flesh trade have started flourishing with the influx of these guests. The large-scale flow of Russians and Israelis began in early-2000. After staying for months with local families, these tourists set up shacks, European-style eateries and shops selling knickknacks. The Anjuna flea market, which began on a 1,000-sq-m space, now spreads across almost 15,000 sq m. The quieter and more secluded beaches like Morjim, Vagator and Anjuna are the scene of rave parties and drug peddling.